

FOR NIHARIKA SAXENA, a one-year executive MBA student at IIM Ahmedabad, the course's rigorous curriculum and transformative approach to learning is proving instrumental in shaping her critical thinking and problem-solving abilities. For women students like her, even a one-year management course from one of the premier institutes in India creates massive opportunities.

"Individuals from various backgrounds such as law, army and medicine have come together here to create a rich tapestry of perspective, and the curriculum is designed to challenge and stretch the students' intellectual boundaries. It pushes us to think critically and analyse complex management problems from various angles, and turns us into active problem solvers, ready to tackle any challenge," she says.

But there's a hitch. The number of top women leaders in corporate India is appallingly low. A recent report by the Confederation of Indian Industry (CII) has revealed that women hold only 14 per cent of the top executive positions in India's Top 500 companies by market capitalisation. Considering that women make up almost half of India's population of 1.4 billion, this figure is startlingly low. Further, the scar-

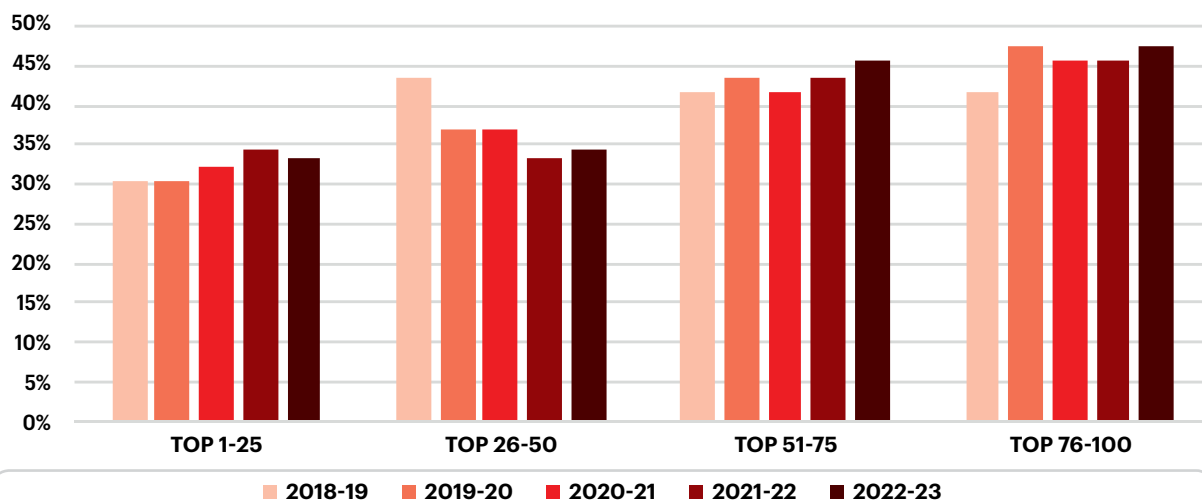
city of women executives within big corporates stems from the marginal share of women students in most top Indian business schools and corporate training programmes. This under-representation, experts point out, raises crucial questions about the systemic barriers that hinder women's entry into business education and their subsequent ascension to leadership roles.

While one hopes that starry-eyed women students like Saxena climb up the corporate ladder and add to the pool of talent in India's boardrooms someday, the gender gap at top Indian B-schools is still far from balanced. In fact, it's amongst the worst, as shown by the AMBA Application and Enrolment Report 2022. Per the report, India had the most unequal cohorts of MBA aspirants for gender, with only 19 per cent women applicants and 20 per cent enrollees in 2021. In contrast, China (including Hong Kong) came out on top as the world's most gender-balanced region in terms of MBA education, with 49 per cent women applicants and 50 per cent enrollees. So, what is the source of the problem?

Most B-school professors in India are of the view that the 'CAT-bias' that persists in admissions to top B-schools is the reason, and it is something that needs to be tackled vigorously for the gender ratios in the colleges to improve. CAT, or the Common Admission Test, is the most prominent entrance test whose scores most

Growing in Moderation

The percentage of women enrolled in the Top 25 B-schools has remained range-bound between 30-35 per cent for the past five years



PERCENTAGE OF WOMEN ENROLLED IN B-SCHOOLS IN INDIA; **SOURCE:** ANNUAL BT-MDRA INDIA'S BEST B-SCHOOLS SURVEY